

Chapter 120_1 - Xuanyuan

Ning Fuyi was stunned for a moment, heat rising from her face. She instinctively reached out with her right hand and placed it on Chu Qingqiu's right shoulder.

The woman leaned into her shoulder naturally, and Ning Fuyi was moved, wrapping both arms around her and holding her tightly in her embrace.

Chu Qingqiu was indeed thin - though she looked like a slender figure, when held in her arms, her waist could almost be encircled completely. Ning Fuyi couldn't describe the feeling in her heart, only holding her close, shielding her from the wind that was useless to her.

The resolute Chu Qingqiu inspired admiration, while this Chu Qingqiu who exposed her softness was maddening.

"After the path of no emotions was broken, my mind became chaotic. In the past, I only felt that protecting all living beings was my destiny, and any sacrifice was nothing compared to that."

"But since the path of no emotions broke, I've gained the joys and sorrows of ordinary people, yet life has become much more difficult," Chu Qingqiu's hair tickled Ning Fuyi's chin.

"How can one live in this world without emotions? Even those gods who commanded you to cultivate the path of no emotions couldn't escape love's control," Ning Fuyi said. "Having human emotions is what makes the mortal world."

"It's alright. I'm here now," Ning Fuyi patted her shoulder.

Chu Qingqiu's shoulder trembled for a moment.

Not far from the two of them, two people were sneakily hiding in the fur, using Bai Lin's cover to peek in their direction.

"This isn't our Yiyi forcing anything - your master took the initiative!" Jiuying laughed, her red lips like fire, mimicking Ning Fuyi's gesture by wrapping her arms around her own shoulders.

Qiu Yi said nothing, but her face turned completely red, feeling that this scene somehow shattered her understanding.

"You'd have to ask those two. I'm not human - how would I know what you humans are thinking?" Jiuying said, then turned her gaze back and suddenly patted Qiu Yi's waist. "Little bird, crouch lower. If they see us later, it'll ruin this beautiful moment!"

Qiu Yi was suddenly touched by those delicate fingers on her waist and almost cried out. Her body quickly dropped down, both hands covering her lips, her ears involuntarily turning red.

Jiuying hadn't expected such a reaction and thought she had hit too hard, so she leaned forward to ask: "What's wrong with you..."

But just as she approached, the woman who had been lying down retreated as if startled. Bai Lin shook its shoulders, and their hidden figures were immediately exposed in the spring breeze.

So Chu Qingqiu's body whooshed out of Ning Fuyi's embrace, her face slightly red, and she leaped coolly into the clouds.

She said calmly: "You rest here. I'll go see how far we are from Xuanyuan Kingdom."

After speaking, she fled in white robes into the clouds like someone escaping.

Ning Fuyi came to her senses, looked down at her own palms, smiled as she closed them, and looked reproachfully at Jiuying, who responded with an innocent shrug.

After about an incense stick's time, Chu Qingqiu returned on the clouds. She landed on Bai Lin's back with moisture all over her, put away the white bone under her feet, and said lightly: "Ahead is an endless desert. The ruins of Xuanyuan Kingdom are hidden in the desert. Sandstorms often rise there, and demons run rampant. We must be careful."

"Good," Ning Fuyi nodded. She also stood up and gazed toward the distant clustered sea of clouds.

"Besides that..." Chu Qingqiu continued, "we're not the only ones heading to Xuanyuan Kingdom."

"Who else?" Ning Fuyi raised an eyebrow.

"People from the immortal sects," Chu Qingqiu replied.

Jiuying, who had been stretching lazily nearby, lowered her long arms and immediately cursed: "I knew that old witch couldn't be trusted! As soon as we left, she immediately notified the immortal sects!"

Ning Fuyi seemed to have expected this and wasn't surprised, smiling: "I never expected her to fully trust us. Besides, it's the immortal sects, not Penglai - no harm."

"Divine Venerable, could you see which sect it was?" Ning Fuyi asked again.

"From a quick scan, I only saw a few familiar figures. Presumably Heaven Profound Sword Sect¹ and Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, plus some people from Flying Flower Sect². Not many in total."

Ning Fuyi nodded: "That's fine then. As long as they don't interfere with our business, let them be."

Bai Lin dove into the fortress-like clouds. When the clouds and mist cleared again, the vast desert spread out below their feet, looking like cracked earth from afar, with strange peaks rising up. Several dust storms rolled from far to near in barrel shapes, sweeping across the already barren ground.

Flying in the sky was too conspicuous, so after entering the desert, the group landed and proceeded on foot.

"The evil qi here is very heavy," Qiu Yi said as she walked, accidentally stepping into a crevice and struggling to pull her foot out. "These rocks jutting out from the ground completely block our vision and make my back feel cold."

She was right. Since landing, they were surrounded by layers of weathered rocks. Every three steps forward, backward, left, or right, there was bound to be one - quite eerie.

Ning Fuyi summoned a wisp of immortal power and injected it into a rock. Sure enough, not only did the rock not shatter, but even the immortal power she injected was completely absorbed without a trace.

Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu exchanged glances, then clapped her hands: "The evil qi has thoroughly permeated these rocks. If I'm not mistaken, we should have already entered the territory that once belonged to Xuanyuan Kingdom."

"Where's any trace of a city here? Isn't this just a barren wasteland with exposed soil?" Jiuying dusted off the dirt from her body, trying hard to avoid the cracked areas.

She reached out to touch a rock several people high, but suddenly trembled and let out a soft gasp.

"What's wrong?" Ning Fuyi instantly moved to her side, and Qiu Yi also ran over quickly.

"Nothing," Jiuying quickly shook her head, her gaze fixed on that boulder, confusion creasing her brow. "Just now my eyes suddenly hurt."

"It felt like someone was watching me."

Hearing this, both women got goosebumps all over. Ning Fuyi patted her back hard: "Don't scare people."

Jiuying was patted into withdrawing her gaze and glanced at her reproachfully, then closed her eyes to spread her divine sense. Soon she opened her eyes and grabbed Qiu Yi's shoulder like she was having palpitations, retreating repeatedly.

"No good - the evil qi here is too heavy. Divine sense can't spread, and even if it does, it'll quickly be corroded by the evil qi."

"This journey is indeed not simple," Ning Fuyi handed her a pill to calm the mind and spirit. "Then don't use divine sense recklessly. If even you're affected, if it were someone with unstable divine sense, they'd probably be devoured by the evil qi."

She instructed Qiu Yi to take good care of her, then quickly walked to Chu Qingqiu: "Let's continue forward. While there's still daylight, if it gets dark later, it'll be even harder to travel."

Chu Qingqiu didn't speak, only nodded in agreement, then turned to walk among the towering rocks. Ning Fuyi stepped forward to walk alongside her, asking in a low voice: "If Divine Venerable is afraid, just hold onto me."

"There are no ghosts - what's to fear?" Chu Qingqiu glanced at her.

"This place is ancient ruins. When Xuanyuan Kingdom was destroyed, it surely left behind many vengeful souls. With such strange terrain, who knows if there aren't some filthy things here," Ning Fuyi said.

Not long after her words fell, a weight settled on her sleeve.

Ning Fuyi smiled.

"Good thing we came down to walk early. Look," Jiuying behind them suddenly pointed at the sky. Everyone immediately looked up to see that the red sun from earlier had been covered by endless gloom, disappearing from sight.

"All miasma," Ning Fuyi withdrew her gaze. The gloom seemed to deliberately trap them on the ground, pressing down like a pot lid, dark and oppressive.

As the group was looking up, suddenly a piercing wailing sound came from the distance. Ning Fuyi immediately summoned her Emei thorns³ and looked toward where the crying came from. The crying grew closer, so shrill it made one's scalp tingle.

"Such resentful wailing, earth-shattering - what kind of person could make such sounds?" Jiuying retreated.

"This isn't crying - it's the sound of fierce wind passing through these rocks," Chu Qingqiu said coldly, pulling Ning Fuyi behind her. "Be careful, the wind is coming!"

Everyone quickly lowered their heads, and just as they did, violent winds roared toward them, blowing everyone sideways. Ning Fuyi quickly waved her hand to form a shield with immortal power, digging her feet into the ground to barely maintain her stance.

This fierce wind's wailing seemed particularly harsh to Jiuying's ears. She crouched down in pain, and Chu Qingqiu seeing this, waved out white silk. Qiu Yi grabbed the white silk and wrapped it around her wrist to prevent being blown away, while simultaneously waving immortal power to shield Jiuying.

"Jiuying!" she called urgently through the wind and sand.

"It's this sound - divine beasts have keen hearing, so her reaction is stronger than ours. Quick, seal your hearing!" Ning Fuyi pressed two points on herself and finally felt the heart palpitations ease.

Chu Qingqiu had naturally reacted long ago, and Qiu Yi also copied her movements, then stumbled down to stuff two pieces of cloth in Jiuying's ears before she collapsed to the ground.

"Damn it, so noisy," Jiuying said weakly through gritted teeth.

1. **Heaven Profound Sword Sect (天玄剑宗)** - One of the major immortal cultivation sects
2. **Flying Flower Sect (飞花教)** - Another cultivation sect that has appeared in previous chapters
3. **Emei thorns (峨眉刺)** - Ning Fuyi's signature weapon, a ring-like weapon that can transform and extend